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The Evolution of National Culture in Modern Egypt: Intellectual Formation and Social Diffusion, 1892–1945

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Introduction

This paper describes both the general historical framework within which modern national culture arose in Egyptian society and its transformation into a major culture within that society.[1] More precisely, it examines the central processes of this development in the formative period: from the culture's incipient emergence in the late nineteenth century (specifically, since the 1890s, when the Egyptian nationalist movement became active) until its initial appearance as a central culture in the society in the mid-1940s (specifically, in conjunction with the Arab League's establishment, under Egyptian leadership, in 1945). The basic thesis is that modernity (*tajdid* or *hadith*, in the language of the Egyptians) was introduced into Egyptian Muslim society through

1. The present paper offers a general, and generalized, summary of some of the findings arrived at in a far more comprehensive study (including all of the relevant sources, only a few of which could be cited here): Israel Gershoni and James P. Jankowski, *Egypt, Islam, and the Arabs*. Vol. 1, *The Search for Egyptian Nationhood, 1900–1930* (Gershoni and Jankowski 1986); Vol. 2, *Beyond the Nile Valley: The Development of Supra-Egyptian National Identity, 1930–1945* (Gershoni and Jankowski [in press]). Jim Jankowski's friendship and intellectual acumen have been a great inspiration for this article. I am also indebted to Ursula Wokoeck for her incisive comments on an earlier draft. Nevertheless, responsibility for the contents of this study is mine alone.

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the modern written national culture (*thaqafa*) and that only by tracing that culture's evolution is it possible to understand the processes underlying the formation, diffusion, and reception of modernity in this society. True, in these processes a central role was always played by intellectual producers and by the intellectual media of transmission: the intellectual communities of discourse, the intellectual salons, the press, journals and books, prose, poetry, and dramaturgy, and the other diverse artifacts of literary culture. However, the evolution of modern national culture cannot be properly understood and explained by an exclusively "top-down" approach; that is, only by studying the role played by the intellectual elite in the culture's formation and transmission (for examples of this approach, see Safran 1961; Gibb 1962: 245–319; Hourani 1970; C. Smith 1983). Equally important is an examination of these processes from "the bottom up"; that is, the channels through which this culture is transmitted and its modes of reception among broad literate sectors in the society. More specifically, in the Egyptian case, the ways by which more popular groups in the society assimilated the national culture through an active process that involved resistance and evasion, as well as subtractive, supplemental, and transformative revisions.

Thus, an essential element in an analysis of the development of modern national culture[2] is the monitoring of the dynamics of the mutual relations and feedback systems between the production of culture and its social transmission and reception. Congruently, an attempt must be made to link the changes brought about by this dynamic process to the specific historical contexts which evolved in the period under discussion.

1. The Framework of the Evolution of Modern National Culture—Principal Features

A profound development in modern Egyptian society was the emergence of modern literate culture and its evolution into a universal culture shared by broad sectors of the society. Until fairly recently—the last quarter of the nineteenth century—"high" written culture was the exclusive domain of the urban ruling classes. Under the aegis of the religious scholars (*ʿulamaʾ*), the men of letters (*udabaʾ*), and the scribal officials of the civil and military services, this "high culture" was shaped and preserved as the system of values, norms, and modes of behavior of the governing elites. The culture's contents and symbols

2. "Culture," as defined here, combines two approaches to the concept, that of C. Geertz, "Ideology as a Cultural System" (Geertz 1973), and that of I. Even-Zohar, "Polysystem Studies," in the special issue of *Poetics Today* devoted to his work (Even-Zohar 1990).

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were derived from the literate cultural traditions of Arab, Persian, and Turco-Ottoman civilizations.

In contrast, the cultures of the society's broader sectors, the "subject classes" (*raʿaya*), were for the most part oral and popular. Their contents and symbols were derived from two primary sources: on the one hand, the tradition of popular Sufi Islam, with its strong mystical components and its affiliation with the universal religious framework of the Islamic *umma*; and, on the other hand, the local Egyptian folk traditions and customs which developed in the Nile Valley region and were assimilated, beginning in the seventh century, into the popular religion of Islam. This dualistic structure of divergent cultures, "high" and "low," "learned" and "popular," survived for centuries, although channels of communication and interaction between the "two cultures" did exist. Sufism and the system of Sufi orders were the most common frameworks for such channels between the elite and the masses in both rural and urban communities (see, e.g., Shoshan 1989, 1991).

During the nineteenth century, the processes of rapid modernization that swept through Egyptian society began to erode this traditional sociocultural structure. In the late nineteenth century, and more visibly during the first half of the twentieth, the central institutions, outlooks, and practices of this structure broke down. The advent of universal modern education and the massive growth of a literate public; the mushrooming of media based on written Arabic; the emergence of secular groups within the intelligentsia which gained control over the literary cultural centers and became major producers of new cultural products; the accelerated urbanization that dramatically expanded the educated urban community, which was the primary consumer of the new literate culture—these processes helped transform written culture into a major symbolic system, conceptual as well as operative, of modern Egyptian society. While in some respects this modern literate culture was merely a sort of universalization of the traditional "high" or "literate" culture, many of its contents and symbols were new, and certainly to most of its "lower" consumer groups it was a complete novelty.

In Egypt, as in many societies, the principal agent of this sociocultural transformation was nationalism. Nationalism provided both a framework for the formation of a modern written culture and an instrument for diffusing its products at the various levels of society (Gellner 1983; A. Smith 1986: 129–226). Nationalism not only sought to introduce "Western" modernity and progress (albeit, not necessarily only Western) as a complete or partial substitute for Egypt's traditional cultures; it also claimed to be forging a new and authentic collective identity, a "new nation," able to inculcate "in its own way" a modern value system and to utilize it in the modern reality. Nationalism thus

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served as a primary agent for three basic cultural needs that emerged in modern Egypt. The first was the need for modernity; the second, for a new, communal identity; and the third was the thrust to implant that modernity and communal identity "in the entire nation, irrespective of differences of religion, social status, ethnic origin or sex" (as set forth in Egyptian civics textbooks of the 1920s; see Amin and al-Bishri [1925]; al-Bishri [1928]; al-Marʿashli [1929]). The essence of the national culture was, then, a continual effort to discover and shape the collective identity of the Egyptian people and the Egyptian land, as well as to adapt it to the rapid and effective (or controlled and selective) reception of the modern value system.

A. *Westernizing Egyptianist Culture*

In the late nineteenth century and the first half of the twentieth, *two* distinct sociocultural processes contributed to the formation of a literate national culture and its reception among different groups within Egyptian society. First, the attempt made by the more Westernized and secular groups of the educated elite to articulate a secular national culture capable of being absorbed by the society, while endeavoring to expunge from it traditional (i.e., Islamic-Arab) sources from which its identity and cultural symbols had been drawn. This Westernized elite formulated a modern culture based on distinctively Egyptian elements. Its contents and symbols were all drawn from the Nile Valley, from what the elite described as the "eternal dialogue between the Egyptian person and the Egyptian environment" (Haykal 1926) and from Egypt's non-Islamic cultural heritages: Pharaonism, Hellenism, and the Roman-Byzantine heritage. Egyptianism encompassed all spheres of cultural activity in the society: politics, collective identity, education, history, journalism, literature, poetry, art, and architecture. Its proponents hoped that it would, in time, establish itself as a comprehensive alternative to the traditional culture, in both its elitist literate form and its popular oral mode.

More specifically, from the political standpoint, the Egyptianist culture posited a framework for a Westernized Egyptian nation-state in place of the supranational Ottoman-Islamic state. As for collective identity, the Egyptianist culture offered the inhabitants of the Nile Valley a secular, territorial Egyptian focus of loyalty, instead of their traditional loyalty to and solidarity with the Islamic *umma*. Culturally, it proposed a "Pharaonized" Egyptian culture rather than the Eastern-Arab culture. And as for societal identity, loyalty to a single Egyptian nation was intended to supersede the whole gamut of loyalties and attachments to such local traditional milieus as the kinship link to the expanded family (*humula*) or tribe, social attachments to the village and the rural environment, or the urban institutionalized affinity with the Sufi order (*tariqa*) and the guild (*hirfa*).

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The principal social bearer of Egyptianist culture was the landed class that emerged in Egypt in the second half of the nineteenth century and became a central social force in Egyptian culture and politics during the first half of the twentieth century. It also included the heavily Westernized, urban, upper middle class of professionals and the nascent bourgeoisie. A number of factors of equal potency—the attractiveness of Western models at the time, personal exposure to European education and culture, and material interests which were best served by an independent Egyptian nation-state—led these elitist groups to espouse an exclusively Egyptian territorial form of nationalism and to promote a cultural value system which was Egyptian, secular, and Western. Their collective self-image was defined by the fervent sense of mission which led them to view themselves as an avant-garde leadership destined to oversee the modernization of Egyptian society. They were convinced that they could design an Egyptianist national culture and foist it on the entire society. The attempt was predicated on the assumption—which time would show to be naive—that the "plebeian," "passive" elements of society, the Egyptian masses, would accept the authority of this self-appointed elite and would follow it, voluntarily or by force, into an era of progress (Kazziha 1977; C. Smith 1983). The elite's self-image was further enhanced by its belief in the historical axiom that the transition from a traditional to a modern order, through rapid, European-style modernization, was virtually inevitable—effectively, a historical imperative. The new order would, moreover, emerge as a full-blown alternative to the old (this approach was especially characteristic of Ahmad Lufti al-Sayyid and the *Jarida-Umma* party; see Appendix; Wendell [1972: 201–93]).

B. *The Islamic-Arab Culture*

The second sociocultural process which affected the development of a literate national culture was more complex. It consisted of an attempt by more traditionalist groups within the educated elite to formulate and inculcate a modern national culture, yet one that was anchored in traditional frameworks of identity and cultural values. Instead of rebelling against the traditional cultures (in either their elitist literate or popular oral mode) and thus undermining long-standing loyalties, the progenitors of the new culture sought to reformulate the tradition so as to rationalize it and bring it into harmony with modern national views and practices. The new national culture, its articulators held, must maintain a constant intercourse with the traditional culture, which even in the "modern" age was the dominant force in the consciousness and modes of behavior of society's broader sectors. These groups therefore objected to the sweeping emulation of a "Western model" of national culture based exclusively on Egyptianist foundations and themes. Instead, they drew on the heritage of Islamic

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civilization, on the legacy of Arabic culture and language, and on prevailing sentiments of solidarity with Eastern peoples. The result was that this elite could adduce a formula for a national culture bearing a more indigenous Islamic-Arab character (for further elaboration, see Appendix).

More specifically, from a political point of view, the Islamic-Arab national culture strove to create a pan-Arabic framework (at times pan-Eastern and pan-Islamic as well) that could supplant the traditional Islamic-Ottoman state and discard the concept of a particularistic Egyptian nation-state. As for collective identity, in this culture Islam and Arabism became the principal foci of identity for the Egyptian community, rather than the traditionalist Islamic-Ottoman loyalty or the Egyptianist affinity. The new perspective held that Arabic language and culture, Egypt's Islamic-Arab history, and the Arab heroes and myths were symbolic reservoirs from which could be constructed modern values, symbols, mythology, literature, poetry, and art. These were depicted as alternatives to the Westernized Egyptianist culture, which derived its contents and symbols from Pharaonic or Greco-Roman civilizations. From the societal standpoint, a new cultural-linguistic loyalty was proposed, transcending the "narrow," territorial, Egyptian "nation" and the traditional local loyalties of kinship, both rural and urban; henceforth, one would owe allegiance to the greater Arab national community.

To its proponents, Islamic-Arab culture offered the "authentic" spiritual answer to the Western cultural challenge. It was a response that the Westernized Egyptianist culture, by its very nature (i.e., shaped according to a Western model by "collaborators"), could not provide. The new Islamic-Arab culture was also perceived to sit better with the need for collective self-defense and self-assertion in the face of an escalating confrontation with the West and the presence of a foreign ruler (the British) on Egyptian soil. In addition, the intimate contact of these indigenous elite groups with the broader sectors of society, their access to "lower" cultures and their insight into the latter's pervasive antisecularism and anti-Westernism, enabled them to draw on popular themes when forming the new culture's symbols and values.

A further assumption made by the formulators of the Islamic-Arab culture was that the very concept of a nationalism imported from the West involved a revolutionary innovation vis-à-vis the traditional Islamic-Egyptian community. Hence it was imperative to introduce the national culture into the broad fabric of society so that its values would blend in with traditional patterns of identity. The same Egyptian society that could not digest the national ideal in its secular, territorial, Egyptianist form (as presented by the more Westernized elite) would

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accept it only if it were transmitted gradually and if it utilized neo-traditional concepts, symbols, and role models drawn from Islam and Arabism. Only by securing traditional legitimization could the national culture hope to bridge the gap between past and present, old and new, between the elite and the rest of the population (for the role of intellectuals in shaping "neo-traditionalist" modes of thought, see Shils 1968; Eisenstadt 1972, 1973).

The social origins of the proponents of Islamic-Arab national culture differed from those of the Egyptianist Westernizers. Rapid population growth, large-scale urbanization, and the expansion of the educational system, particularly during the interwar period, produced a large urban stratum of students who eventually entered either state service or the private sector in a variety of positions: as bureaucrats, clerks, technicians, engineers, physicians, managers, accountants, and journalists. These educated groups, the "new professional class" (Egger 1986; Erlich 1989: 46–138), generally came from the urban middle or lower-middle strata. In Egyptian terms, they were known as the "*effendiyya* class" (Quraishi 1967: 36–37; Ramdan 1968: 66–82, 130–87; Deeb 1979; Gershoni 1983: 228–33). The *effendiyya* constituted the principal social milieu for the production, diffusion, and initial consumption of national culture in its Islamic-Arab version. More closely attuned to the indigenous Islamic culture of Egypt, yet at the same time disillusioned by the failures of the European-style Egyptian nation-state—which had become obvious by the 1930s—these groups sought a form of modern national culture which was grounded more in Egyptian native traditions and influenced less by Western concepts. The more religiously inclined elements of this "other Egypt" redefined Egyptian national culture in Islamic terms; the more secular-minded among them found an authentic form of national culture in a linguistically based Arab nationalism. For the latter, the ideas inherent in an Arab nationalism based on language and culture offered a more congenial cultural worldview—one which was authentically Egyptian and at the same time wholly modern—than did a religion-based Islamic culture (Gershoni and Jankowski [in press]).

II. The Structure of Cultural Transmission

During the period under discussion, the intellectual life of the broader sectors of the educated public (which produced, diffused, and consumed the Egyptianist or Islamic-Arab culture) was played out largely in cultural circles which revolved around newspapers or periodicals (Safran 1961: 126–27; Gershoni 1980). To the educated public, these publications were embodiments of intellectual, literary, or political schools of thought. To a lesser extent, literary salons, official and unofficial political clubs, religious movements, educational curricula

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and textbooks produced by the Egyptian Ministry of Education, and the University of Cairo also served as agents of cultural production and diffusion (Gershoni 1980). In addition, through the medium of national culture, they all propounded the concept of modernity, of culture as representing modernist images, discourses, and practices. By doing so, they made a crucial contribution to the spread and consolidation of modernity (or forms of neo-traditional modernity) throughout the society.

More specifically, this structure hinged on two leading groups of intellectuals who were cultural producers and disseminators. The first consisted of a handful of intellectual "luminaries" or "great thinkers" who generally founded and led these circles. They determined the creative content and the modes and directions of diffusion of the cultural production itself (Safran 1961: 62–180; Gershoni and Jankowski 1986: 77–227). The second group comprised many subgroups of "secondary" intellectuals and writers, each of whom basked in the light of an individual luminary; these groups usually included both the luminary's disciples and the initial "consumers" of his ideas and attitudes. Under his guidance, and with his collaboration, these second-rank intellectuals set out to produce and diffuse cultural creations directly or indirectly associated with their intellectual master's school (Gershoni and Jankowski 1986: 89–95).

The line between the two categories cannot always be sharply defined. For example, in the period under discussion, several of the secondary intellectuals attained the status of luminaries (notably, Tawfiq al-Hakim, Muhammad Lutfi Jumᶜa, Zaki Mubarak, ᶜAbd al-Wahhab ᶜAzzam, and Ahmad Hasan al-Zayyat; see Appendix). Then, too, the relative ideological homogeneity of the two groups, their deep sense of social commitment, and their intense involvement in public life united them into a single entity that produced and diffused the national culture. Nevertheless, it is methodologically important to differentiate between the two categories of intellectuals in order to provide an analytical framework for understanding the processes of cultural transmission within the specific Egyptian context. It bears noting that the distinction was also recognized and generally accepted by members of the intelligentsia (see, e.g., Haykal 1933: 14–16; Musa 1938: 85).

The intellectual luminaries were perceived, both by their audience and themselves, to be the most creative and influential thinkers of the time: the shapers of the society's "high culture" (Gershoni and Jankowski 1986: 89–95). Ahmad Lutfi al-Sayyid, Muhammad Husayn Haykal, ᶜAbd al-Qadir Hamza, Taha Husayn, ᶜAbbas Mahmud al-ᶜAqqad, Salama Musa, Tawfiq al-Hakim, and Ismaᶜil Mazhar are only a few key articulators of the Westernizing Egyptianist culture who belonged to this category; creators of the Islamic-Arab culture from this category

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included Mustafa Kamil, Muhhib al-Din al-Khatib, Ahmad Hasan al-Zayyat, Zaki Mubarak, ʿAbd al-Wahhab ʿAzzam, Ahmad Amin, and the later Haykal and ʿAqqad (see also Appendix). At all events, during the period under discussion the "high culture" propounded by these intellectual luminaries gradually lost its elitist orientation. This was brought about by their direct involvement in social and political life (most of them were not academics; some were leaders of political parties and movements, or senior civil servants) and by the fact that the very purpose of their intellectual activity in the "national era" was to forge a culture oriented toward the "whole nation" (Gershoni and Jankowski 1986). Thus, "extraneous materials" on a massive scale were introduced into the "high culture," particularly folk themes and motifs in the form of songs, tales, metaphors, and myths which were drawn directly from the oral or written tradition of the popular "lower" culture. The process was strikingly reflected in fiction—both the short story and the novel—in drama and poetry, the fine arts, including painting and sculpture, and in the popular songs of the period. Thus, for example, in the 1920s the proponents of "Egyptian national literature" (see Appendix) infused the "high" art and literature they produced with Egyptian folklore elements from daily village life; and in the following two decades, the advocates of "Arab literature" (see Appendix) introduced genres, themes, legends, and myths taken from the life of the Prophet and his Companions, from Sufi popular beliefs, and from "low" medieval Islamic-Arab literature into the modern Arab literature which they shaped.

In addition, although the intellectual luminaries considered their primary role in society to be the production of the major themes of national culture, their constant need for direct interaction with their target publics impelled them to act also as the diffusers of this culture. To this end they edited mass-market periodicals, wrote works of popular history, fiction, poetry, and drama, and delivered public lectures and radio broadcasts—all geared specifically to inarticulate audiences (see, e.g., Amin and al-Bishri 1925; Husayn 1925, 1933; Taymur 1927; Haykal 1935, 1937, 1942; ʿAzzam 1938).

However, in terms of sheer cultural transmission, the groups of "secondary" intellectuals—or, more generally, the "reproductive" publicists—played a more meaningful role (for further theoretical elaboration, see Shils 1968, 1973; A. Smith 1981; Gershoni and Jankowski 1986). A number of factors—their own collective self-image, the expectations placed on them by the intellectual luminaries, the nature of their cultural activity—led them to view their primary role as one of diffusion, after first popularizing or even vulgarizing authoritative texts, cultural concepts, and social perceptions formulated and produced by first-rank intellectuals. This is nowhere better exemplified

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than in the periodicals of the time (most of which also represented different publishing houses). These journals were edited by the intellectual luminaries, who determined along general lines their literary, cultural, and/or political stances. But it was the secondary intellectuals who did the main work of writing the articles and columns and of managing the publishing houses. In most cases, the staff of a periodical consisted of one luminary-editor, or perhaps two, and a few dozen second-rank intellectuals. The operations of *al-Siyasa al-Usbuʿiyya*, *al-Balagh al-Usbuʿi*, *al-ʿUsur*, *Majallati*, and *al-Majalla al-Jadida* and their affiliated publishing houses are good examples from the category of Westernizing Egyptianist culture, while the thrust toward Islamic-Arab culture is well illustrated by the modes of operation of *al-Fath*, *al-Risala*, *al-Hilal* (in the 1930s), *al-Rabita al-ʿArabiyya*, *al-Thaqafa*, *Jaridat al-Ikhwan al-Muslimin*, and *Jaridat Misr al-Fatah* and their affiliated publishing houses. Effectively, these groups of hundreds of secondary, or reproductive, publicists, while not as creative or original as the luminaries, played a more crucial role in disseminating the texts and other artifacts of national culture.

As for their professions and their status among the educated public, these reproductive publicists were generally academic lecturers, schoolteachers, journalists, preachers, government officials, leaders of religious movements or political parties, heads of literary or journalistic clubs, mentors of artistic circles, or individual writers, poets, and artists. Through their preaching, writing, teaching, and exhibiting, they spread the concepts, themes, and genres of national culture among the broader sectors of society. Most of their activity took place in the urban arena, but their influence was also felt in the rural milieu.

In many ways the transmission process, as carried out by these publicists, was in itself an act of cultural production. In reformulating the texts and other products of national culture, whether in oral or written form, they transformed them into a "lesser" literature designed for mass diffusion and for consumption by the "ordinary" mind—the "natural" target of national culture. They played a crucial role in promoting a dialogue between the elite and the popular levels of society and in molding that "common culture" which incorporated both elitist and popular elements. They functioned as a social linchpin, mediating from their position at the vortex of reciprocal influences between the creative level of the national culture and its "consumers" and "absorbers." In this role of cultural intermediary, they were, to a considerable degree, executing the designs of the intellectual luminaries by striving to establish "lower" (or "national") forms of discourse with the popular mind in order to transform what was originally produced as "high" culture into a universally accessible one.

The secondary intellectuals' intimacy with the broader sectors of

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society, their pivotal role at the production centers of national culture, and their close links with the intellectual luminaries enabled them to act as a conduit for cultural feedback from the popular mind to the elite mind, and vice versa. They were the principal agents of the mutually reinforcing trends that mark the process of the production, diffusion, and consumption of national culture. Such trends were especially characteristic of the Egyptian milieu within the context of the Islamic-Arab cultural system's ascendancy in the 1930s and 1940s (see Appendix). As catalysts of the mutual feedback systems, the reproductive publicists frequently effected transformations or reorientations in authoritative texts. They exercised a decisive influence over the dynamics that produce cultural authority and hegemony, and they had a major impact on the acceptance or rejection of cultural interpretations. The cultural and journalistic endeavors of more populist movements, such as the Young Men's Muslim Association (YMMA), the Muslim Brothers, Young Egypt, various student bodies, and pan-Arabist societies and organizations, were instrumental in stimulating these sociocultural processes.

The activity of these intellectual groups went a long way toward narrowing the gap between the elite and popular cultures. After the 1930s, in particular, they played the central role in channeling the new literate national culture toward mass production, mass diffusion, and mass marketing. In this function they brought about a massive assimilation of elements of high culture into popular culture, while also "elevating" broad segments of the latter. The *Islamiyyat* literature which flourished in the 1930s and 1940s—the production of popular Islamic publications by leading intellectuals and periodicals devoted to biographical material on the Prophet Muhammad, the Rashidun Caliphs, and other prominent classical Islamic heroes—illustrates this process well (see Appendix).

Besides managing the *literate* media, the secondary intellectuals (together with the luminaries) also exercised control over three very specific types of *oral* media of cultural transmission which developed into quite sophisticated instruments of dissemination in this period. The first was the institution of the *circle* (*halaqa*): a gathering of small learning groups around a local mentor on either an ad hoc or a more permanent basis (see, e.g., Mitchell 1969: 185–208). The second was the *café*: an "institutionalized" gathering, on a regular daily or weekly basis, of groups in particular coffee or tea houses, centering in each case on a leading personality (ibid.: 4–19, 185–208). The third was the *mosque*, the more traditional mode for disseminating cultural norms and political messages. This major institution was revitalized in the period under review following the establishment of thousands of official and unofficial new mosques, particularly in the big cities, enabling

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far more men and women than ever before to attend Friday services (ibid.: 3–34, 185–208, 328–31; Gershoni 1986). It was especially through these institutions that the secondary intellectuals transmitted elements and themes of the national culture to illiterate audiences.

III. The Dynamics of the Cultural Polysystem

Throughout the period being surveyed, the two modern cultural systems—Egyptianist and Islamic-Arab—competed over the shaping of national culture and its diffusion in society. The historical emergence of the two systems and their directions of development over time were in part determined by the constant tension that prevailed between them, that is, by the dynamics of their struggle for domination in the realms of cultural production and among the instruments of dissemination, and for hegemony among consumer publics at different levels of society. At the same time, the proponents of the two systems waged a "common struggle" against the traditional cultural systems (literate as well as oral) that they strove to replace or renew. As a result, the growth of the modern national culture occurred within the broad context of the complex evolution of the entire *polysystem* (i.e., a system of cultural systems [Even-Zohar 1990: 9–26]) of Egyptian life and society during the late nineteenth century and the first half of this century.

It is important to note that every cultural system within this polysystem was, on the one hand, an individual, autonomous system propelled by a distinct internal dynamic (the Egyptianist and the Islamic-Arab, as they sought to formulate a new national culture, and the traditional systems, as they attempted to preserve the old cultural norms and values) and by specific themes and symbols. On the other hand, and simultaneously, each of these systems was also heteronomous, dependent on its neighboring systems and part of the entire heterogeneous cultural polysystem. Each functioned by being conditioned by the other systems of that polysystem, and each conditioned those others in turn (ibid.: 9–26, 85–94).

In terms of historical development, we have to examine the status, cultural influence, and political and social impact of each system at every point in the period under discussion and in the light of its shifting, particular contexts. The various specific thrusts of each system within the polysystem must be weighed in relation to all the other systems operating within it. We must examine the movement from the periphery to the center, and vice versa, of each system as it seeks to establish its dominance over the sociocultural center of the polysystem and to eject, or at least weaken, competing cultural systems or options.

From the end of the nineteenth century until World War I, the struggle between the Egyptianist and Islamic-Arab cultural systems

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was not intense. As they were still in the incipient stages of intellectual formation, their influence palpable only among educated elite groups, and with old cultural patterns (the traditional culture) still exercising a significant degree of influence over Egyptian life, tension between the two systems was slack, latent rather than manifest. At the same time, it can be said that the Egyptianist system enjoyed cultural hegemony among groups of the "high" elite (particularly landowners and educated members of the upper class) as well as within the bureaucracy and government, which were to a large degree British-run institutions. In contrast, the Islamic-Arab system enjoyed cultural hegemony among middle-level elites, among nonelite and saliently traditional Islamic groups like the *ʿUlamaʾ*, and among educated middle-class publics in urban centers (Gershoni and Jankowski 1986: 3–20).

It was only after the war that the struggle between the two cultures became fierce, overt, even at times violent. In terms of the dynamics of the polysystem, the primary questions relate, on the one hand, to the historical conditions which created a situation enabling the Egyptianist cultural system to gain ascendacy within Egyptian literate society during the first part of the period, 1918–1933, and, on the other hand, to the historical circumstances which brought about a radical cultural reorientation during the second part of the period under review, the mid-1930s and the 1940s. It was in this later period that the Islamic-Arab culture achieved supremacy and hegemony within literate society. The immediate answers to the two questions must be sought in "simple" historical factors, "external" to the cultural dynamics themselves. The disappearance of the traditional Ottoman order, the abolition of the Caliphate, the general sense of impending revolutionary change, enhanced by the 1919 revolution and the rapid processes of secularization, modernization, and Europeanization (see Appendix) heavily supported by the British government in Egypt—all of these developments greatly strengthened the Westernized elite's role in the country's intellectual and political life during the 1920s and, concomitantly, the increasingly decisive influence wielded by Egyptianist culture and by Egyptian territorial nationalism over the entire society. The potency of the Westernized elite, including Egyptianist culture, was manifested in its control of the political establishment and its domination of the cultural center. This elite effectively exploited the state's instruments of cultural transmission, such as information services, the communications network, and the educational system—for example, the production of an entirely new set of textbooks (Gershoni and Jankowski 1986: 40–74, 77–254). As we have shown in some detail (see Appendix), the Egyptianist culture exercised its hegemony through the central and most widely circulated newspapers and peri-

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odicals of the time. It engendered a dynamic cultural creativity bearing an Egyptianist, secular character that became pervasive in fiction, poetry, drama, historical writing, and the fine arts.

The hegemony enjoyed by Egyptianist culture over the sociocultural center produced a corresponding temporary retreat of the traditional and Islamic-Arab cultures, away from the center and toward the periphery. Concretely, this took the form of a loss of authority among intellectual elite groups and a consequently drastic falloff in the cultural and literary creative activity which had exploited traditional or Islamic-Arab materials. That the more traditional cultures found themselves at the periphery was due also to a strong anti-Arab and anti-Islamic backlash among the articulate urban publics. The new mood was reflected in the "official ideology" of the ruling elite (government policy and party platforms), in diverse social polemical writings, in historical literature, and in the fiction, poetry, and art of the period (Gershoni and Jankowski 1986: 77–227).

In the 1930s and 1940s, nearly all of the historical factors that had brought about the rise and consolidation of Egyptianist culture waned or disappeared altogether. The parliamentary Egyptianist order and the "liberal experiment" suffered severe setbacks and were wracked by ever more frequent crises as the economic and social situation worsened at home, while external "pressures," generated by powerful influences originating primarily in Italy and Germany, intensified (Safran 1961: 181–208; al-Sayyid Marsot 1977: 138–251; Deeb 1979: 221–338). The continual erosion of the parliamentary regime and the constitutional institutions was paralleled by the decline of the landowning class and the loss of political hegemony by the secular and Westernizing forces within the rapidly changing urban society (Issawi 1954: 258–76; Deeb 1979: 311–422). The processes of secularization and Europeanization were stymied by the reassertion of neo-traditional Islamic trends and a general resurgence of romanticized Arab sentiments in Egyptian society. These found expression in a strengthening of the Islamic religious establishment centered on *al-Azhar* (Kedourie 1970: 198–207; Jankowski 1981a; C. Smith 1983: 109–57), in the emergence of strong Islamic populist movements in major urban centers and provincial towns (Heyworth-Dunne 1950; Husaini 1956: 1–16; Mitchell 1969: 7–19), and in an intensifying pan-Arab orientation among the urban educated public (Gershoni 1981). An important expression of the movement of Islamic-Arab culture from the periphery to the political and cultural center was dynamic intellectual and cultural creativity in journalism, history writing, literature, poetry, and drama (see Appendix). On the social level, the urban sectors, and particularly the new urban masses, increasingly tended to accept and absorb this culture and to help foster it. One effect

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of these developments was to greatly strengthen the *effendiyya* groups politically and culturally. The new conditions enabled these groups, and through them the Islamic-Arab culture they espoused, to achieve a growing dominance over systems of rule, education, communications, and other official and unofficial organs of cultural dissemination (Gershoni and Jankowski [in press]: pt. 1).

The hegemony of Islamic-Arab culture generated a corresponding marginalization of Egyptianist culture. The authority and hegemony previously enjoyed by the latter over a large proportion of the intellectual elite groups during the 1920s were sharply eroded in the next two decades. Cultural and literary creativity that drew heavily on Egyptianist territorialist materials and Pharaonic-Hellenistic traditions declined drastically, a process hastened by the rapid spread of strong anti-Pharaonic, antisecular, and anti-Western sentiments in public opinion of the 1930s and 1940s. These were given "official expression" in the revised programs of governments and parties, in the propaganda of new, extraparliamentary political forces, in blatantly populist social and political polemics, and in popular historical literature as well as in fiction and poetry (Gershoni and Jankowski [in press]: pts. 2 and 3).

However, understanding the profound historical shift that occurred within the cultural polysystem entails more than merely pointing to historical "external elements" that were instrumental in bringing about the metamorphosis. It is also essential to locate the "internal" factors of change that were integral to its dynamics. As we argued earlier, in the processes of culture diffusion a crucial role was played by the secondary intellectuals and the media of transmission which they controlled and operated. During the 1930s and 1940s, the structural changes undergone by Egyptian society (notably, accelerated and widescale urbanization, along with a radical expansion of the elementary, high-school, and university systems) produced a surge, both quantitative and qualitative, in the growth and evolution of these groups of secondary cultural brokers. Moreover, in this later stage nearly all of them came from the *effendiyya* social stratum, which was also the social bearer (i.e., the producer and disseminator) of Islamic-Arab culture. This later period witnessed a related development as well: with the great expansion of the *effendiyya* class and its growing political and social influence (to the point where a new stratum, the "new *effendiyya*," emerged) came a large increase in the groups of secondary intellectuals originating in this social stratum. Thus, the new secondary intellectuals and reproductive publicists became the disseminators of the Islamic-Arab culture, which was, as we saw, the culture of the new *effendis*. In other words, during the late 1930s, and even more emphatically in the 1940s, the entire system of dissemination of the

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national culture was increasingly controlled by the new *effendiyya* (i.e., by the *effendiyya* class's secondary intellectuals and secondary media of transmission) and, through them, by the Islamic-Arab culture (Gershoni and Jankowski [in press]: pts. 1 and 2).

The change in the structure of transmission was nourished and spurred on by a change in the system of reception. In order to understand the dynamics of the polysystem, we must turn our attention also to the development of the patterns of reception of national culture in the society. The processes of cultural reception were by no means passive. The "consumer" publics did not accept "external" cultural products imposed on them unilaterally "from above" by ruling elites. Once past the initial stage, in which they were purely intellectual creations, the products of national culture began to be disseminated and diffused among the broader sectors of Egyptian society, passing through several specific stages of reformulation, adaptation, and compromise. These phases involved continual changes of content and theme, the rejection of particular elements and symbols, and the introduction of substitutes. In all of these stages the "consumers" of cultural products played a critical role. The various types of consumers—readers, listeners, and viewers—absorbed the culture by reevaluating and reconstructing its elements. They reorganized and rebuilt the national culture as "their own culture"—one that was harmonious with their established norms and values and complementary to their ways of feeling and behaving (for further theoretical discussion, see Chartier 1982; La Capra 1985; Toews 1987).

The social diffusion of national culture was thus a two-way process of consumption by reproduction. On the one hand, the culture shaped its consumers according to the constructs, images, and norms of its intellectual producers. Yet, simultaneously, it was reformulated by its consumers as they reinterpreted the culture and invested it with different meanings (at times quite distinct from the intellectual original) derived from their own particular prisms of convention, imagery, and symbolism. The more that national culture became diffused among broader sectors of society, the more its very essence became dependent on those sectors.

In the specific context of Egypt during the 1930s and 1940s, the change in the patterns of reception was intimately linked to massive urbanization, with its consequently steep growth in the urban population. The entry of huge rural masses into the sociopolitical urban arena and their socialization into a new, urban, literate society greatly broadened, and thereby altered, the markets that consumed literate products. This process was played out on three interrelated planes. The first consisted in a large-scale acquisition of literate urban culture (fluency in literary Arabic became a virtual "ticket" into urban life, as

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Arabic became a major focus of cultural identity). The second plane entailed participation in the shaping of a new, collective sense of belonging to the urban Islamic-Arab community as a political-, social-, and cultural-identity framework. For the newly urbanized masses, literate, urban, Islamic-Arab culture became a substitute loyalty framework for the oral, popular Islamic (or folk-Egyptian) culture of the now-abandoned rural community. The third plane consisted of the formation of a new human milieu of a more populist and traditionalist nature that was incapable of assimilating the symbols and values of a Westernizing, secular national culture carrying an innate anti-Islamic and anti-Arab message (Gershoni and Jankowski [in press]: pts. 1 and 2).

Thus, in these sociocultural processes, which peaked in the 1940s, the uprooted masses that had abandoned traditional rural communities and crowded into the big cities (especially Cairo and Alexandria) rejected as alien most of the products of the Egyptianist system of national culture, with its secular, Westernist, and Pharaonic trappings. At the same time, through their very urbanization, these new urbanites also lost, once and for all, their traditional oral culture, with its underpinnings in popular Islam, and their previous rural foci of loyalty. At this moment of a "crisis of urbanization" and a "search for identity," only the Islamic-Arab culture could offer them both adequate compensation for the forsaken traditional patterns of life and a functional system of neo-traditional symbols (based on Islam and Arabic) with which they could identify and through which they could interpret, and experience, the rapidly changing world around them. The very processes entailed by a mass reception of the national culture that were involved in its reformulation vis-à-vis a mass-market audience—and the correspondingly heightened receptivity to Islamic-Arab cultural products within the now-dominant urban community—played a decisive role in the Islamic-Arab system's gradual takeover of the sociocultural center. Toward the close of the era under study, this culture achieved a position of hegemony within the cultural polysystem and, more generally, throughout the entire urban society (Gershoni and Jankowski [in press]: pts. 1 and 2).

Appendix
Milestones in the Historical Evolution of National Culture in Egypt

1. *The Egyptianist Culture*

An incipient organized effort to shape a Westernized Egyptian culture and to diffuse it among the educated social strata is traceable to the turn-of-the-century ideas and activities of the *Jarida-Umma* party (Kazziha 1977; al-Shaliq 1979). At the intellectual level, members of this group had begun to formulate and dissemi-

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nate their ideas by the 1890s. Politically and organizationally, the group flourished from 1907 to 1914: a flowering reflected in Qasim Amin's books and essays on women's liberation and on the necessity of granting equal opportunities and equal rights in modern Egyptian society (Amin 1899, 1901; Ahmed 1960: 47–51; Hourani 1970: 164–70), in the translations into Arabic by Ahmad Fathi Zaghlul of many major works of philosophy, sociology, psychology, and history from late nineteenth-century European (particularly French) literature (Zaghlul 1899; Ahmed 1960: 44–46; Kazziha 1977: 374–78), and especially in the nationalist philosophy of Ahmad Lutfi al-Sayyid, who laid the theoretical foundation for Egyptian territorial, nationalist ideology (Ahmed 1960: 85–112; Wendell 1972: 201–93). These may be seen as initial systematic efforts to shape a Westernized Egyptian national culture. The central medium for transmission of the ideas and ideals of this intellectual community in the years from 1907 to 1914 was the biweekly journal *al-Jarida*. Under the management and editorship of Lutfi al-Sayyid, *al-Jarida* was, from its first year of publication, a prestigious and highly influential platform (Wendell 1972: 216–17; Kazziha 1977: 379–84). Its "stable" included a good many young, talented writers and intellectuals. It attracted an increasingly large, articulate reading public and it cultivated devoted partisans who were willing to struggle for its ideas (C. Smith 1983: 37–46). This entire school of thought was soon given political expression with the establishment of the *Umma* party (which also operated from 1907 to 1914, *al-Jarida* becoming its official organ), most of whose members and supporters were from the landowning class. This party, which enjoyed the backing of the British authorities, became the major social and political power base for the formation of Westernized Egyptian culture, contributing greatly to its transmission to and reception by various elite groups in the society during the years preceding World War I (Kazziha 1977: 378–84; al-Shaliq 1979).

Despite wartime, British-imposed martial law and censorship, the activities of this cultural school persisted. The periodical *al-Sufur* (the direct successor to *al-Jarida*) and the lively intellectual salon that flourished around it, under the tutelage of Mansur Fahmi and Muhammad Husayn Haykal, continued to promote Westernized Egyptian cultural orientations (Brugman 1984: 232–34).

The end of the war, followed by the nationalist revolution of 1919, generated new and favorable historical conditions for the production, transmission, and, especially, the reception of a Westernized Egyptian culture. In fact, from 1918 to 1933 this culture attained hegemony among the literate public (Gershoni and Jankowski 1986). Its influence was palpable in virtually every sphere of postwar Egyptian public life. In the realm of journalism, nearly all of the newspapers and journals of the period (many of them founded in those years) contributed, each in its own way, to the intellectual consolidation of an Egyptianist culture and to its aggressive dissemination among members of the rapidly growing reading public. The dailies *al-Siyasa*, *al-Ahram*, and *al-Balagh* and, even more so, the weeklies *al-Siyasa al-Usbuʿiyya* (edited by Muhammad Husayn Haykal), *al-Balagh al-Usbuʿi* (edited by ʿAbd al-Qadir Hamza), *al-Hilal* (edited by Salama Musa), *al-ʿUsur* (edited by Ismaʿil Mazhar), and *al-Fajr* (edited by Ahmad Khayri Saʿid) stood out in the 1920s as shapers of public opinion and molders of public taste in conformity with Westernized Egyptianist cultural discourse and patterns of behavior (Gershoni and Jankowski 1986). In terms of literary, artistic, and poetic production, this period was characterized by a remarkably dynamic efflorescence of original and innovative Egyptian creativity. The ideal of producing an "Egyptian national literature" (*Adab Qawmi Misri*) was ardently promoted by the country's finest fiction writers, poets, and artists (Semah 1974: 75–95; Gershoni and Jankowski 1986: 191–227). One result was the extensive introduction of modern Western genres into Egyptian literature. The short story, particularly the work of such talented young authors

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as Mahmud Taymur, Mahmud Tahir Lashin, and Yayha Haqqi (Brugman 1984: 249–68; Hafez 1984); dramaturgy, as practiced most notably by Tawfiq al-Hakim (Long 1979; Badawi 1987: 8–43; Starkey 1987); sculpture, such as that produced by Mahmud Mukhtar (Karnouk 1988: 3–18; Ghazi 1964), and painting, as exemplified by the work of Mahmud Saʿid (Karnouk 1988: 18–25), both of whom made extensive use of Pharaonic symbols and of rural Egyptian folk themes; the new Arab-Egyptian poetry which was developed by the *Diwan* school, especially the poetry of ʿAbbas Mahmud al-ʿAqqad, Ibrahim ʿAbd al-Qadir al-Mazini, and ʿAbd al-Rahman Shukri (Badawi 1975: 84–116; Brugman 1984: 94–150); the ideas and activities of *al-Madrasa al-Haditha* (the "Modernist school"), led by Husayn Fawzi, Ibrahim al-Misri, Yahya Haqqi, Tahir Lashin, and Mahmud Taymur, who challenged all forms and techniques of the traditional Arabic *Adab* and advocated radical modernism in art, literature, and music (Brugman 1984: 249–68); and the publication of Tawfiq al-Hakim's extremely influential novel *ʿAwdat al-Ruh* (Return of the Soul) in 1933 (al-Hakim 1933; Badr 1976: 376–97; Jad 1983: 50–56)—all gave expression to and, in turn, shaped the Westernized Egyptian Zeitgeist. They were diverse manifestations of that national effort to mold the culture of the people of the Nile Valley into a modern Egyptian, secular, Westernized culture.

Dominant at that time was the Egyptian territorial, nationalist ideology, with its pronounced Pharaonic thrust and its anti-Arab and anti-Islamic concepts. Salama Musa, Taha Husayn, Muhammad Husayn Haykal, Ismaʿil Mazhar, Ahmad Amin, and Tawfiq al-Hakim all contributed to its being intellectually formulated according to European models, while the newspapers and periodicals mentioned above were the agents of its social diffusion (Gershoni and Jankowski 1986: 130–90). In the political sphere, it was the *Wafd* and Liberal-Constitutionalist parties, the two leading political parties of the 1920s, that became the living embodiments and primary representatives of Egyptian territorial nationalism. Domestically, they promoted a liberal political culture, while in their foreign policy they espoused a pro-European position. The obverse side was an attitude of indifference, even hostility, toward the Arab world (Gershoni and Jankowski 1986: 40–54, 231–54; al-Shaliq 1982: 477–517). Its powerful degree of populist appeal enabled the *Wafd* to play a crucial role in the mass transmission of Egyptianist values (Deeb 1979: 38–75, 150–82). In addition, the liberal constitution of 1923 (drawn up by politicians aligned with these camps), as well as both houses of the Egyptian parliament and occasionally, the Palace, under King Fuad, expressed the ideals and principles of Egyptianist culture (Safran 1961: 108–64; al-Sayyid Marsot 1977: 73–137).

In the second half of the 1930s, Egyptianist culture lost much of its attractiveness and its status declined among the educated public. However, this was a gradual development, and the Egyptianist influence continued to be felt. The journals *al-Majalla al-Jadida* and *Majallati* (Gershoni 1987) and the new romantic school in Arab-Egyptian poetry, which formed around the periodical *Apollo*, under the inspiration of the modernist poet Ahmad Zaki Abu Shadi (al-Dasuqi 1960; Badawi 1975: 115–45; Brugman 1984: 151–204), continued in this period to act as platforms for the production and transmission of Westernized Egyptian cultural values. Husayn Fawzi, Ismaʿil Adham, Salama Musa, the young Najib Mahfuz, and most importantly, Taha Husayn, with his polemical book *Mustaqbal al-Thaqafa fi Misr* (The Future of Culture in Egypt), were prominent individual spokesmen for an Egyptianism with a Mediterranean or European orientation (Husayn 1938; Gershoni and Jankowski [in press]: pt. 2). Various groups in the *Wafd*, as well as certain independent politicians in the Egyptian parliament, continued to cultivate and defend the principles and norms of political behavior inherent in Egyptianist national culture (Deeb 1979: 311–423).

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2. *The Islamic-Arab Culture*

The main historical foundation for the formation and transmission of an Egyptian national culture with a strong Islamic-Ottoman orientation had been built on the views of the young Mustafa Kamil, enunciated in the early 1890s, and on his activities as leader of *al-Hizb al-Watani* (the "Nationalist Party"). Nevertheless, Kamil did not have to start from scratch. At the end of the nineteenth century and early in the twentieth, various factors—the Eastern-Islamic "nativism" of ʿAbdalla al-Nadim, with its anti-Western bias (Wendell 1972: 140–61); the neo-traditionalist Islamic writings of Talaʿt Harb and his demand for a limited conservative reform in the status of Muslim women (Harb 1905; Cole 1981; Baron 1988); the ideas and activities of Shaykh ʿAli Yusuf, expressed through his Islamicist journal *al-Muayyad* (Goldschmidt 1968; Wendell 1972: 228–29); and the neo-classicist Arabic poetry of the "national poets" Ahmad Shawqi and Hafiz Ibrahim (Khouri 1971)—contributed, each in its own way, to the formation of Islamic-Arab culture. However, it was only with the founding of *al-Liwaʾ*, in 1900, as the first mass-circulation paper, its transformation into the official organ of *al-Hizb al-Watani*, and the militant national struggle waged by the *Watanists* against British rule that this Islamic national culture became a significant political and social force (Goldschmidt 1968; Walker 1980–1981). In the years from 1906 to 1914, this nationalist struggle was led by Kamil, then by his successors in the Nationalist Party, Muhammad Farid and ʿAbd al-ʿAziz Jawish, and finally, by an increasingly large group of young militant nationalists who followed in their footsteps. Articulating nationalist slogans which called for a determined and uncompromising political struggle against the British (e.g., "the full and absolute liberation of the land of the Nile from foreign rule," and "unity of the Nile Valley"), and consistently espousing support for the integrity of the Ottoman Empire and the Ottoman Caliphate, the militant nationalists were able to spread Ottoman-Islamic cultural values among broad and influential sectors of literate society (al-Rafiʿi 1941; Goldschmidt 1968; Jankowski 1980; Nasr 1984: 59–116). Numerically, the sympathizers with and "consumers" of this cultural and political orientation totaled many tens of thousands (some 80,000) in this period—exceeding the numbers of those who were disposed to accept the Westernized Egyptianist cultural orientation (Walker 1980: 374–83, 1981: 79–110).

During World War I, the British authorities completely and effectively banned these nationalist activities. After many of the Nationalist party's leaders were arrested and deported, its influence waned perceptibly. Nevertheless, its exiled leaders and activists—particularly those based in Istanbul, but also those in various European capitals—went on trying to attract supporters and to make their views known in Egypt by underground means (al-Rafiʿi 1941: 387–443; Farid 1978: 147–446).

Following the war, in the aftermath of the shock caused by the British victory, the Turkish defeat, and the final collapse of the Ottoman-Islamic framework, the proponents of Islamic-Arab culture found themselves on the political and intellectual periphery. But their presence was still felt. Toward the end of the 1920s, they experienced a certain recovery. The activities and views of Muhibb al-Din al-Khatib and the publishing house he founded, *al-Matbaʿa al-Salafiyya*, which put out the Islamic-Arabist periodicals *al-Fath* and *al-Zahara* (Gershoni 1976); the Salafite-Islamic ideas of Muhammad Rashid Rida and the *al-Manar* circle, which continued to be disseminated during the 1920s in Egypt and the Arab world (Gershoni 1980: 103–4); and, more importantly, the opposition activity of the orthodox *ʿulamaʾ* under the leadership of *al-Azhar* that aimed at containing the Westernizing, secularist, and Egyptianist trends (Safran 1961: 141–67; Kramer 1986: 86–105; Gershoni and Jankowski 1986: 55–74)—all demonstrated the existence of a demand for

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concepts and ideas of these kinds among more traditionalist and popular circles. In the late 1920s and early 1930s, it was the Society of the Eastern Bond (*Jamiyyat al-Rabita al-Sharqiyya*) and its organ, *Majallat al-Rabita al-Sharqiyya*, that were the focal point of the Islamic-Arab cultural orientation (Gershoni and Jankowski 1986: 255–69). Such intellectuals and politicians as Ahmad Shafiq, Ahmad Zaki, Mansur Fahmi, and ʿAbd al-Hamid al-Bakri stood out as activists in this group and were major contributors to its journal. Theirs was a post-Ottoman effort to reformulate a modern worldview holding that the culture of the Egyptians was Eastern-Islamic in origin, rather than a local Egyptian or a Western one, and, moreover, that this culture was an integral part of the "Eastern civilization" of all the "Eastern peoples" (Gershoni and Jankowski 1986: 256–67).

In the 1930s and 1940s, Islamic-Arab cultural trends and schools dominated literate society. Their growing influence was evident in virtually every sphere of Egyptian life during this period (Gershoni and Jankowski [in press]). Two highly significant shifts occurred in the Egyptian press. First, daily newspapers (notably, *al-Ahram* and *al-Balagh*) and periodicals (especially *al-Hilal* and *al-Siyasa al-Usbuʿiyya*) which had previously promoted a Westernized Egyptianist culture underwent a reorientation, becoming proponents and disseminators of Islamic-Arab culture (Gershoni and Jankowski [in press]: pt. 2). Second, a press of a new type emerged, which from the outset considered its sole purpose to be the production and transmission of Arabic and Islamic culture and literature in Egypt. The daily *al-Jihad* and, more specifically, the cultural and political periodicals of that time—*al-Risala*, *al-Thaqafa*, *al-Rabita al-ʿArabiyya*, *al-Fath*, *Jaridat al-Ikhwan al-Muslimin*, *al-Nadhir*, *al-Ansar*, *al-Sarkha*, and *Jaridat Misr al-Fatah*—contributed to the formation of new reading publics and to the extensive assimilation by these readers of Islamic-Arab artifacts and themes in the realms of culture, society, literature, education, and politics (Gershoni and Jankowski [in press]; Gershoni 1981).

In terms of literary production, this period was marked by the far-reaching ramification of writing that comprised non-canonical, popular, Islamic literature (*Islamiyyat*), which was intended from the outset for mass consumption by broad, "low" sectors of the literate society. Prominent in this creative outpouring, in which Islam was reshaped as a modern cultural system shared by the elite and the masses, were such new and gifted writers as ʿAbd al-Wahhab ʿAzzam, ʿAbd al-Rahman ʿAzzam, Ahmad Hasan al-Zayyat, Zaki Mubarak, and Muhammad Rida Effendi (Gershoni and Jankowski [in press]: pt. 2). But it is important to note that veteran intellectuals (who had previously been committed to the Westernized Egyptianist culture) also contributed to the production of this literature; among them were Haykal, Taha Husayn, Tawfiq al-Hakim, al-ʿAqqad, al-Mazini, and Ahmad Amin. These older writers now saw as their primary task the formation of a "common" national culture, to be based on Islamic values and themes that were oriented toward broad audiences (Safran 1961: 165–80, 209–28; C. Smith 1983: 109–57; Gershoni and Jankowski [in press]). As for poetry, the romantic verse of ʿAli Mahmud Taha, the most popular poet in Egypt and the Arab world of the 1930s and 1940s, was suffused with Arab and pan-Arab nationalist motifs and ideals (Taha 1972; Badawi 1975: 137–45; Brugman 1984: 173–81).

In the sociopolitical sphere, new and potent supra-Egyptian nationalist ideologies emerged: Egyptian Islamic nationalism, "integralist" Egyptian nationalism, and, most importantly, Egyptian Arab or pan-Arab nationalism (Gershoni 1982). By the late 1930s, these had achieved hegemony in the nationalist political domain. All three ideologies challenged the inherent isolationism of Egyptian territorial nationalism; all were critical of its innate Pharaonic and Westernistic orientations; and all strove to integrate Egypt into a supra-Egyptian-identity framework: Arab,

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Islamic, and Eastern. All perceived the Egyptian nation as an Islamic Arab one, as the "natural leader" of the Arab world and, beyond it, of the whole Islamic *umma* (Gershoni 1980). Two central processes were at work in the political realm. First, the adoption by the official parties (including the Palace and its affiliated politicians) of new strategies and policies for the Arab and Islamic domains. This entailed the reversal of their past isolationist policy and of their indifference toward the Islamic and Arab countries. Operatively, these new strategies were manifested in the heightened involvement of Egyptian governments in inter-Arab affairs, especially the question of Palestine and the struggle of Arab national-liberation movements in the Fertile Crescent and North Africa against the mandated rule of the French, British, and Italians. This increased involvement on the part of the Egyptian ruling elite peaked in 1945 with the creation of the Arab League, based in Cairo and under Egyptian leadership (Gomaa 1977; Jankowski 1981b; Mayer 1983; Porath 1986). The second process was the emergence and growth in the 1930s and 1940s of extraparliamentary political forces, which posed a severe challenge to the established political system. At the poles of this development were the Muslim Brotherhood, with its radical Islamic-Arabist message (Mitchell 1969), and the Young Egypt party (*Misr al-Fatah*), which advocated an "integralist" Egyptian nationalist doctrine (Jankowski 1975). These two organizations won a broad social and political following among the new lower-middle classes, particularly in the big cities. Both also enjoyed rising popularity among the young. Each espoused a political culture (in fact, a political counterculture) which was militantly anti-Western and anti-Egyptianist, and which consciously strove to undermine and even destroy the constitutional parliamentary structure that had been formed in the 1920s. The Free Officers movement, which would foment the revolution of 1952 and establish a republican revolutionary regime, evolved in the cultural and political hotbed of these two extraparliamentary organizations (Jankowski 1975: 118–24; Vatikiotis 1978).

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